

LESSON 3 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Proportions

How to see and measure the true size and relationship of every part.

Overview

Proportion is the relationship between sizes. A face with correctly proportioned features reads immediately as a face. Change one proportion slightly — the eyes too close, the forehead too short — and the brain knows something is wrong, even if the viewer can't name what. This lesson trains you to see proportional relationships accurately instead of drawing what you think things look like.

This is one of the hardest lessons because it fights against conceptual knowledge. You know a hand has five fingers — so your brain draws five equally spaced, evenly sized fingers. But hands aren't like that. Learning to draw from observation means silencing that conceptual knowledge and recording what you actually see.

CORE CONCEPTS

The Canon of Human Proportions

The classical figure is 7.5 to 8 heads tall. The width of the shoulders is about 2 heads wide. The waist sits at 3 heads down, the hips at 4, the knees at 6. These are starting points — not rules. Every body deviates from the canon, and those deviations define the individual. Learn the standard first, then learn to see where reality differs.

The Portrait — Proportions of the Face

The most important proportion in portraiture: the eyes sit at the **midpoint of the head**, not near the top. Most beginners draw eyes too high. The nose is halfway between the eyes and the chin. The mouth is one-third of the way from nose to chin. The ears align from eye level to nose level. These relationships hold across most faces, regardless of age, gender, or ethnicity.

Sight-Sizing & Comparative Measurement

Hold your pencil at arm's length. Close one eye. Align the top of the pencil with the top of your reference and slide your thumbnail down until it aligns with the bottom — that's your unit of measure. Now compare: how many of those units tall is the full figure? How many across? How does the head relate to the torso? Constant comparative measurement is what separates observational drawing from guessing.

Negative Space

The shape of the space *around* an object is as useful for accurate drawing as the shape of the object itself. If you're struggling to get the proportions of a figure right, look at the negative shape between the arm and the torso. That shape has a precise boundary on both sides — draw it accurately and the arm falls into place.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Head Proportions — 30 minutes

- Draw a simple egg shape. Mark the midpoint — that's eye level.
- Add the eyes, nose, mouth, and ears using the proportional relationships above.
- Do this from imagination 5x, then 5x from a photograph reference.
- Compare both sets. Identify which proportions your imagination consistently gets wrong.

EXERCISE 2

Figure Proportion Grid

- Draw 8 stacked "head" units as a grid column. This is your 8-head figure.
- Mark the shoulders (1.5 heads), waist (3), hips (4), knees (6), ankles (7.5).
- Use this skeleton to place a stylized figure — no musculature needed. Just placement.
- Repeat using a different head count: try a "heroic" 9-head figure and a "childlike" 5-head figure.

EXERCISE 3

From Life — Self Portrait

- Sit in front of a mirror with your sketchbook. Draw your own face from observation.
- Before any mark: measure. Where do your eyes actually sit? Check against the midpoint rule.
- Take 45–60 minutes. Resist the urge to rush. Re-measure every 10 minutes.
- Photograph the result next to your reference. What proportional errors can you identify?

CURATED FREE RESOURCES

Proko — Figure Drawing (YouTube Channel)youtube.com/@Proko · Video Channel

The best free figure and portrait drawing instruction online. Watch the full proportion series first.

Proko — Portrait Drawing (Playlist)youtube.com/@Proko · Video Series

Dedicated portrait proportions series: eye placement, nose, mouth, skull structure.

Drawing on the Right Side of the Brain (Betty Edwards)drawright.com · Book

Classic book with exercises for negative space, sighting, and proportion. Available via library or Google Books preview.

Andrew Loomis — Figure Drawing for All It's Worth (Free PDF)alexhays.com/loomis · Free Book

Public domain book with the clearest classical canon of proportions available. Essential reference.

SenshiStock — Free Figure Drawing Reference Photossenshistock.deviantart.com · Reference Photos

High-quality free reference photos of figures in varied poses for proportional study.

Line of Action — Figure & Portrait Drawing Practiceline-of-action.com · Tool

Free timed figure drawing tool. Use 5-minute poses for proportion studies, not gesture.

New Masters Academy — Proportions of the Figureyoutube.com/@NewMastersAcademy · Video

Classical atelier approach to measuring and constructing the human figure.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: 5 heads from imagination. Time yourself. Don't erase — just note where proportions went wrong and do the next one.

Weekly: One 45-minute observational portrait from life (mirror, friend, or photo). Measure constantly.